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Diplomacy: Representation with responsibility

Africa is more visible now than ever before in global governance, with its demographic and economic importance increasing and major powers competing for its partnership in the very settings of the G20, BRICS and the like.

However, with representation comes responsibility; thus, the necessity for continental alignment on priorities cannot be overstated. Without this, and as the Institute for Global Dialogue's Faith Mabera agrees, the continent risks entering another cycle of dependency and a missed opportunity to treat multipolarity not as a slogan but as a "space of struggle, where it can advance its own priorities."

In the face of divergent national and sub-regional ambitions, overlapping memberships to regional economic groupings and an African Union whose credibility is undermined by limited resources and inconsistent delivery, continental alignment is often difficult to define or translate into real influence.

It requires coherence, strategic planning and fundamental political willingness to act collectively. South Africa must make clear that pathways for such action include achieving independence for continental and regional institutions, bolstering technical capacity for engagement on complex continental issues, strengthening enforcement of continental initiatives such as the African Continental Free Trade Agreement and ensuring that national objectives are aligned with continental goals.

In learning from the South African Institute of International Affairs' Gustavo de Carvalho, these efforts may constitute a calculated advancement of the continent's structural capacities and pragmatic adaptation to enduring systemic limitations, which, in turn, have the potential to define global governance transformation.

At present, the durability of multilateralism is itself uncertain. The United States, once its chief architect, has increasingly discredited BRICS and the G20 while wavering in its own commitment to collective governance under the Trump administration.

Its upcoming G20 presidency introduces both a warning and an opening for South Africa post its own presidency – a warning that progress achieved through cooperation can easily be undone, but also an opportunity to consolidate gains and defend the principle of shared problem-solving.

For South Africa, the lesson is clear: in a fragmented order, multilateralism remains the most practical instrument of agency for middle powers. By pursuing economic, security and diplomatic objectives in BRICS, the G20, and others, South Africa can help preserve what still works, reform what must change, and build a foundation for cooperation that endures.